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The Delights of Coming Back

It had been quite some time since I last worked with glue and mechanical supplies. As a college student, and with the fast-paced Dartmouth terms, it is hard to do hardly anything creative with my hands except for typing on a laptop. When I started the process of creating as many variations of a square as possible, I felt the delightfulness of stepping out of a traditional way of doing homework. Whether it was during lunch at FOCO or just before going to bed, I tried to sketch and draw alternatives of a square first.

The Little Prince could draw a boa constrictor eating an elephant while also demonstrating a hat, so I can also do that? I thought to myself. Towards the end of my idea creation, I came up with the card soldiers, just like in Alice in Wonderland! Drawing was a very enjoyable part of the process to me, because I could “verbalize” my ideas in a sketch form.

The most difficulty came up when I actually started working with the pencil and paper. Being able to cut paper in an intended shape is challenging, it turns out. Precision and accuracy was leading me to throw away a lot of cut papers, even though they were fairly fine. I caught myself being a perfectionist and comparing my work to those of others in extra help sessions. However, I remembered that vertical thinking, or a Fixed Mindset, was making me feel like there would only be one perfect outcome, ignoring all the other work I had done. With lateral thinking,

or a Growth Mindset, I proceeded with what I thought was moderately well-cut and showed what I wanted to convey.

When we represented our squares in the class, I was amazed how people interpreted the homework guidelines differently. One student created a bird within the square, while another one built a 3D formatted square. It was interesting to realize that we tend to set limitations ourselves and make assumptions, thus limiting our imagination.

Time management apparently will help me succeed in the class, as projects or things that require hand work take longer time than anticipated. Even though drawing tremendously helped me complete this project, I underestimated that directly working with the paper is a different experience, and I should not wait until the last minute to get things started. Lastly, catching ideas right away in my notebook is a fairness to my mind and creativity. Although I have had a personal notebook for many years, I tend to write only to-do lists or random thoughts, rarely drawing or sketching anything. The design log exercise helped me value the essence of visualizing this project.